back to the pavilion, disappointed to have been dismissed one run short of a century.

Under these circumstances, it was frustrating to watch a replay of the incident later in the day and to see that, in fact, beyond any doubt, the ball had bounced before it was grasped by the fielder. So much for the spirit of cricket, I muttered. In future, I resolved, I would leave the decisions to technology.

We won the Test at Centurion, but then lost in Durban and approached the decider in Cape Town.

2012

For all our talent and ability, we had not actually won a home Test series since 2008. That was the fact. We had drawn five, and we could have – and should have – won most of them. However, it was high time we nailed down a series win in front of our own supporters, and we duly did so, batting with conviction against Sri Lanka at Newlands. Alviro Petersen made a fine 109 and Jacques produced an imperious innings of 224 before we declared at 580 for four.

It had been another special day, and I was pleased to have contributed an unbeaten 160, playing carefully until I reached three figures and then unleashing some flamboyant strokes to entertain the capacity crowd: a few cuts, a few lap-shots, a few drives. Everything was going my way, and I enjoyed every minute.

The first match of the ODI series was played in Paarl, and I captained the team for the first time. I worked hard to prepare properly, tried to think through various scenarios and was relieved when everything seemed to go well. Our plans seemed to work, and we won – and we won in East London, and we won in Bloemfontein.

With the series win sealed at 3–0, the tourists won the fourth and fifth matches, with Kumar Sangakkara scoring a brilliant century as his team